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A final checklist

A summary of points to keep in mind.

Part of: **How to write text descriptions (alt text) in BBC News articles**

Contributors



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Information to include

- Think about describing the image to someone on the phone who does not have it in front of them. Will your text description convey the content of the image clearly and sufficiently?
- Avoid using terms like "picture of" or "image of". Screen readers explain when something is a graphic, so there will be unnecessary audio repetition for screen reader users.
- Use terms like "illustration of", "sketch of" or "watercolour of" when appropriate, as

this indicates the style of the image.
- Never reuse an image from another piece without giving careful consideration to the text description which may come with it. Remember, text descriptions are very dependent on the context in which they're being used.
- When describing people remember you must adhere to the BBC News style guide which says: ethnicity must only be mentioned if it's editorially relevant to the story.

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Clarity

- Keep your text descriptions brief and descriptive, providing a clear summary of the visual information present in the image.
- 150 characters is a good rule of thumb. But this could be more depending on the level of detail needed. For example, complex images might have to be longer.
- To keep the text descriptions shorter, ensure the information you leave out is available elsewhere in the piece.
- Make your text descriptions easy to understand, using plain language and avoiding technical jargon and abbreviations.

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Remember your readers

- Remember why you're writing text descriptions and who they're for. Humanising the need for text descriptions in this way will help you create the most meaningful content.
- Ask colleagues who use screen readers if the text descriptions you've written contain enough information, bearing in mind that this is still only one person's opinion.
- Practice! Practice! Practice! Writing the most impactful text descriptions is a skill. It will come in time so don't be hard on yourself if you don't get it right straight away. The fact you're trying is a fantastic start.

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Other questions to ask yourself

- Why have I chosen this particular image?
- What information is the image conveying?
- Is the information available elsewhere in the piece?
- What is the feeling or sentiment I am trying to portray?

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More information

Here's where to find out more on accessibility and text descriptions:

- **BBC Digital Accessibility Hub**, BBC login required.
- Download a practical guide for **accessibility of social media** from the BBC Academy
- **How to add text descriptions to Microsoft Office 365 products**

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How to write text descriptions (alt text) in BBC News articles

About text descriptions

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